Report card comments for English language learners

Find the student's stage of English. Use one **can do now** line and one **next** line, then add a strength, what they show in other subjects and one thing to try at home. Swap [Name] and "their" for the student, and change anything that isn't true of them.

New to English (about WIDA level 1)

	Can do now	Next
Listening	[Name] follows simple instructions, especially when they come with gestures and pictures.	Next, [Name] is working on following two-step instructions in class.
Speaking	[Name] is starting to use single words and short phrases to ask for help and join in.	Next, [Name] is working on using short sentences to ask for help and answer questions.
Reading	[Name] is learning letter sounds and recognizes some familiar words with picture support.	Next, [Name] is working on building a bank of everyday words to read.
Writing	[Name] copies words, labels pictures and is starting to write simple words without help.	Next, [Name] is working on writing short sentences with a sentence starter.

Early stages (about level 2)

	Can do now	Next
Listening	[Name] understands short instructions and familiar classroom talk.	Next, [Name] is working on understanding the key words in each new topic.
Speaking	[Name] speaks in short phrases and simple sentences about familiar topics.	Next, [Name] is working on speaking in full sentences in class discussions.
Reading	[Name] reads short, simple texts with pictures and familiar words.	Next, [Name] is working on reading simple texts and answering questions about them.
Writing	[Name] writes simple sentences using sentence starters and word banks.	Next, [Name] is working on writing two or three linked sentences.

Developing (about level 3)

	Can do now	Next
Listening	[Name] follows most class talk on familiar topics and picks out key information.	Next, [Name] is working on picking out the key details in longer explanations.
Speaking	[Name] takes part in class discussions in longer sentences, sometimes pausing to find the right word.	Next, [Name] is working on explaining ideas with reasons, using words like because and so.
Reading	[Name] reads grade-level texts with support and understands the main idea.	Next, [Name] is working on learning the new words in grade-level texts.
Writing	[Name] writes short paragraphs with support, using some new topic words.	Next, [Name] is working on planning and writing a short paragraph without help.

Expanding (about level 4)

	Can do now	Next
Listening	[Name] understands most class discussions, including on new topics.	Next, [Name] is working on asking questions to check understanding in longer discussions.
Speaking	[Name] explains ideas and reasons in class discussions with growing confidence.	Next, [Name] is working on using subject words when explaining ideas.
Reading	[Name] reads grade-level texts with some help for new words.	Next, [Name] is working on finding evidence in a text to explain their answers.
Writing	[Name] writes organized paragraphs and is starting to use linking words such as because, however and so.	Next, [Name] is working on using a wider range of linking words and sentence openings.

Nearly fluent (level 5 or above)

	Can do now	Next
Listening	[Name] understands class discussions and follows detailed explanations.	Next, [Name] is working on noticing how speakers back up their points.
Speaking	[Name] explains, describes and gives opinions clearly in discussions.	Next, [Name] is working on giving reasons and examples in longer answers.
Reading	[Name] reads grade-level texts independently and works out new words from the context.	Next, [Name] is working on reading more challenging texts.
Writing	[Name] writes well-organized pieces of writing.	Next, [Name] is working on choosing precise words and checking their own writing.

Strengths that aren't about English

- [Name] has a go at speaking English, even when unsure, which takes real courage.
- [Name] has settled well into our class routines.
- [Name] has made good friends and joins in at recess.
- [Name] is a kind classmate who notices when others need help.
- [Name] works hard in every lesson and takes pride in their work.
- [Name] asks questions when something is new, which helps their learning.
- [Name] listens carefully and watches closely to understand what's happening.
- [Name] has taught our class words and greetings in their home language.
- [Name] is quick to help in class, whether that's handing out books or tidying up.
- [Name] comes into class with a positive attitude and a smile.

What the student shows in other subjects

- [Name] shows a good understanding of math, especially when problems use numbers, pictures and models.
- [Name] understands our science topics well and shows it in diagrams, models and practical work.
- [Name] expresses ideas confidently in art and design.
- [Name] joins in fully in PE and games, which is also a great way to build everyday English.
- [Name] brings real enthusiasm to music and picks up songs quickly.
- [Name] reads and writes in their home language, which is a real strength to build on.
- [Name] shows understanding in many ways, including drawings, models and talking with a partner.

Things to try at home

- At home, keep reading, talking and telling stories together in your home language. A strong home language helps children learn English.
- At home, ask [Name] to tell you about the school day, in any language. Talking about learning helps it stick.
- At home, borrow library books in English and in your home language, and talk about the pictures together.
- At home, listen to stories or audiobooks in English together for a few minutes a day. Hearing English for fun builds vocabulary.
- At home, ask [Name] to teach you three new English words from school each week.

Phrases to avoid, rewritten

Instead of	Write
Mateo has limited English.	Mateo speaks in short phrases and simple sentences about familiar topics. Next, he is working on speaking in full sentences in class discussions.
There is a language barrier with Aisha.	Aisha follows our class routines and simple instructions, especially with pictures and gestures, and is starting to use single words to ask for help.
Wei can't speak English yet.	Wei is starting to use single words and short phrases to join in, and he answers questions by pointing and drawing.
Sofia's English is poor, so her science grade is low.	Sofia understands our science topics well and shows it in diagrams and practical work. In English, she is now learning to write short explanations with a word bank.
Yusuf is an ESL student who struggles in reading.	Yusuf reads short, simple texts with pictures and familiar words. Next, he is working on answering questions about what he reads, in our small reading group.
Hana is very shy and won't speak in class.	Hana listens carefully and watches closely to understand what's happening. She answers with gestures and single words, and she is starting to talk with a partner.
Dmitri's parents don't speak English, so homework isn't done.	Dmitri finishes homework best when we go through it together first, so we now do that at Thursday lunchtimes. If it would help, we can arrange an interpreter for a meeting; please get in touch.
Please speak English at home with Lina.	At home, keep reading, talking and telling stories together in your home language. A strong home language helps children learn English.
Ahmed is a refugee and has had a hard time.	Leave it out. "Ahmed has settled well into our class routines and has made good friends at recess."
Priya came from India last year and is still behind.	Leave where the family is from out. "Since joining our class, Priya has started reading grade-level texts with support, and she is working on the new words in each topic."
Carlos is behind native speakers in writing.	Carlos writes simple sentences with sentence starters and word banks. Next, he is working on writing two or three linked sentences.
Ana's accent makes her hard to understand.	Ana explains her ideas in class discussions with growing confidence. Next, she is working on using subject words when she explains.
Kenji is making leaps and bounds and is on track.	Kenji now reads class texts with some help for new words and has moved from short sentences to short paragraphs this quarter.
Omar is at WIDA level 2.1 in writing.	Omar writes simple sentences using sentence starters and word banks. Next, he is working on writing two or three linked sentences.
Lucia is in the silent period and has weak receptive skills.	Lucia follows our class routines and simple instructions, especially with gestures and pictures. Next, she is working on following two-step instructions.
Nour probably has a learning disability because she isn't picking up English.	Don't write it. Talk to your EL and special education colleagues and the family first. The report can say what Nour does now and what helps.
Tomasz is an EAL pupil with no English.	Tomasz has settled well into our class routines and is starting to use single words and short phrases to ask for help and join in.
Fatima is weak in math because of her language.	Fatima understands number well when problems use numbers, pictures and models. Next in English, she is learning the words for explaining her working.

80 lines. Free from polytheseus.com/teacher-skills/guides/report-card-comments-for-english-language-learners, where a free builder puts them together and checks the wording. Drafted with AI help: read every line against what you know of the student before using it.